

Born in 1914 in Springfield, Massachusetts, Abrams grew up in modest circumstances in the nearby town of Agawam. At the age of 17, he entered the US Military Academy at West Point, graduating in 1936 alongside William Westmoreland. He began his career in horse cavalry but soon switched to the armored branch.

Abrams first saw combat in World War II, commanding the tank battalion that spearheaded General George Patton's Third Army advance through Europe. An aggressive and talented leader, he led the relief of the besieged 101st Airborne Division at Bastogne during the Battle of the Bulge. Patton called Abrams "the best tank commander in the Army."

During the Korean War, Abrams served as chief of staff of three different army corps. In 1963, and by then a lieutenant general, he commanded V Corps in West Germany, on the frontline of the Cold War. As US involvement in Vietnam deepened, President Johnson promoted Abrams to the rank of general (over the heads of several three-star generals), alongside Harold K. Johnson and William Westmoreland. From this group, the president made Johnson US Army chief of staff, Abrams vice chief of staff, and Westmoreland commander of MACV.